On a Wednesday, In a Café...

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Teen And Up Audiences

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by queenmillicentofbystander

Summary

Catra and Adora were childhood best friends, but time changes a lot and now they barely know each other. Now Adora's a mom and Catra's got a cat. They meet up for lunch and old feelings resurface. Is anyone going to address them?

No, probably not.

Notes

The title comes from a Taylor Swift song. A song that I did not listen to once while writing this fic. Instead I listened to 19 by Xana. That should tell you how this goes.

This is a super personal fic for me, and I wrote it because it felt cathartic. And because ResFlower said they wouldn't.

Catra and Adora are about 27 in this. That's... yeah, there ya go.

Also, I gave Catra a good mom. Because I have a good mom. And I'm projecting.

See the end of the work for more notes

15 years ago…

Catra was sitting on her bedroom floor, tears running down her cheeks hot and fast. Her legs were pulled up to her chest and she was clutching the phone in her hand.

She'd never been so angry. She'd never been so hurt. And she'd never screamed so loud. So it wasn't a surprise when only a few minutes after hanging up the phone and tearing her own throat to shreds, there was a quiet knock on the door.

"Come in," she whispered, and the door cracked quietly.

It was her mom, C'yra, and the little girl inside Catra cried out. She wanted to run into her mother's arms and sob into her chest. She wanted her to hug her until all the pain went away. But she stayed on the ground, curled in on herself, wallowing in the ache.

"Hey," her mom whispered, stepping through the door and closing it quietly behind her. "You okay, babe?"

Catra gave a curt nod and set the phone down on the plush purple carpet underneath her.

C'yra tsk, inviting herself to sit down beside Catra and pulling her own knees to her chest. "What happened?"

Catra sighed and started picking at the grass stained tear in her jeans. She'd fallen one too many times. Usually running around with Adora and Adam in the field near their house.

She wondered briefly if they were going to do that anymore.

"A few weeks ago I asked Adora if she wanted to go trick or treating together," Catra admitted. It was October 28 th . Her birthday and three days before Halloween. She hadn't had a party, just a family dinner and presents, but usually Adora still would've come over. She was busy though, apparently. That night her cousin had some play or something. Still, Catra had assumed that

she'd be home by now, and she could call and they would make plans for Halloween.

"Okay," C'yra said, waiting for her young daughter to go on.

"I just called her," Catra's voice got thick. "I wanted to plan, but…" Catra choked on her own tears. "She said she's going to a party instead. With her friends from the volleyball team. And when I said she promised, she—" Catra dissolved into sobs then, burying her head in her knees. "She said she didn't think it counted as a promise. And then she said we hadn't talked about it in weeks."

Catra lifted her head, anger reinvigorating her. "Which isn't my fault! She's always busy and we don't have the same lunch anymore and she never calls me back—"

"Hey, hey, hey," C'yra wrapped her arm around her and held on tight.

Catra shuddered, swallowing her tears. "She's supposed to be my best friend. But it's like she doesn't even like me anymore…"

C'yra sighed, rubbing her hand up and down Catra's arm. "Sweetheart, I don't think that's it. I think… I think Adora is being pulled in a lot of directions at once."

Catra nodded, leaning her head on her mother's shoulder. "I know…"

"But," she went on, "she shouldn't have bailed on you like that. That was unkind."

Catra bit her lip as a fresh wave of tears threatened. "I just… miss her."

Her mother nodded and gave Catra another squeeze. "Did I ever tell you about my best friend Susan?"

Catra lifted her head, brow furrowed in confusion. "The one you went to your High School Reunion with?"

C’yra nodded, brushing Catra’s hair from her eyes. “She and I met our senior year of high school. I didn’t really have friends before that – and definitely not a best friend. But I met Susan and we just clicked.”

Catra frowned, anxiety creeping into her heart. “If Susan’s your best friend, why do we never see her?”

C’yra sighed. “Well, things happened. I met your dad and we got married. And then I moved here and she moved to Erelandia. But, and this is the important part kid, are you listening?”

Catra nodded, scooting a little closer.

“We haven’t changed. When I see her, even though it’s not a lot, it is exactly as it always was. We still make the same jokes and feel just as comfortable. Because it doesn’t matter where our lives take us, we are always going to be friends.”

Catra swallowed. “Really?”

Her mother nodded. “Yes. And I think you and Adora are like that. You are always going to know each other, at the core, where it matters. You’ll always find your way back to each other. You’re… well, bonded.”

Catra took a shuddery breath. “You really think that?”

“Yes,” Catra’s mom pressed her forehead to her daughter’s.

Catra nodded, and she felt a quiet calm settle over her.

“Mom,” she bit her lip, “is Susan still your best friend?”

Her mom smiled, “Well, yes, sort of. But I have a bester friend now.”

Catra frowned. “Who?”

Her mother ruffled her hair. “Your dad, dummy.”

Catra rolled her eyes. “Oh.”

“Someday, Catra,” her mom patted her knee, “you’re going to meet someone so special, and they’re going to be the best friend you ever had.”

Catra bit her lip and her eyes filled with tears. “Promise?”

“I promise.”

Now …

Catra pulled into the parking lot of what she assumed was considered the local hole-in-the-wall diner. Immediately it felt… lackluster. The sign was dingy, just the word “Café” in large, red letters that she assumed lit up at night, even though they closed at four. It wasn’t even in a fun font.

She’d never been to Thaymor before, never really given it a second thought. But it was about halfway between FZC and Bright Moon, which meant she didn’t have to drive a full hour each way. Thus it was the perfect spot.

And this just happened to be the diner with the highest reviews on Google.

Catra swallowed as she turned off her car and stared through the large glass windows. She was looking for a bouncy blonde ponytail, maybe even a white and red letterman. But the windows were too dark and the glare from the sun was too bright.

She pulled her phone from her bag, scrolling through the recent messages. There was one from Entrapta asking if she knew where they kept the vacuum, another from her mother asking if Catra was coming to dinner that night and informing her that they were having stroganoff.

And there was one from Adora Gray.

Adora Gray: Hi! I just got here. I'll get us a table!

Catra took a deep breath and closed her eyes. This shouldn't be scary. There were so many things she'd done that were scarier. But the anxiety that was climbing up her throat and thrumming through her limbs was paralyzing and itchy.

Still, she managed to open her car door and step out.

The sun was bright and beating warm against her neck. The sound of cars on the main road was loud and, for some reason, discouraging. But she made her way to the heavy glass door and slipped inside the cold, quiet restaurant.

She kept her head down as she reached the Hostess stand. The tile under her feet was a bland beige and she knew, she just knew, that if she looked up, the booths would be lined with cracking red vinyl.

"Hello!" the hostess beamed, grabbing a menu off a rack and a roll of silverware. "Just one."

Catra straightened and filled her lungs. "No. I'm meeting someone. The name's—"

"Catra!"

Catra jerked her head to follow the sound of her name, and there, in the corner booth, sitting tall and waving with the world's brightest smile on her face, was Adora.

Everything about her was the same, even when it was completely different. She was wearing a blue and yellow flannel opened over a white tank top – no letterman in sight. Her long blonde hair was framing her face, with just a few locks pulled up by a tiny hair elastic – and not enough of it to be considered a ponytail. And, wrapped around her left ring finger, a white gold band with an emerald cut diamond – the blue, red, and purple braided friendship bracelet Catra had made with so much care and love… gone.

Catra swallowed her heart and smiled.

“Hey, Adora.”

She walked to the booth and forced herself to maintain eye contact. Everything in her screamed “look down, turn around, and run away,” but she kept walking.

She took a seat across from Adora and forced more joy into her smile. Because that’s what she wanted to feel. She wanted to be happy. She wanted to be thrilled.

Adora looked happy. Adora looked thrilled. Adora looked beautiful.

And that hurt.

“Hey,” Adora beamed, fiddling with the edge of her napkin. Catra’s smile twitched with genuine joy. Adora had never been good at sitting still, especially when she was excited. It was nice to know she was still like that.

“Thanks for coming,” Adora nearly whispered, and the way she was looking at Catra was so soft and warm it made Catra’s skin crawl. “I’ve been wanting to do this for a while.”

Catra cocked her head, a small smirk playing at the corner of her mouth. “Really?”

Adora bobbed her head and pulled her hands into her lap. “I haven’t seen you since Finn’s first birthday. And that sucks.”

Catra let out a quiet laugh. “You’re a mom, Adora. Are moms even allowed to have friends, or social lives?”

Adora’s mouth fell open with a gasp. “Yes!” She leaned back in her seat and gave Catra a smug smile. “I have a great social life.”

Catra rolled her eyes. “Your brother and stepsister don’t count.”

Adora furrowed her brows and her lip jut out into the cutest little pout. “Does Teela?”

Catra arched a brow. “You mean your brother’s wife?”

Adora scrunched up her nose. “What about Bow?”

Catra scoffed. “Bow? Please. He and Glimmer have been joined at the hip since before your parents got married. He’s basically a Glimmer accessory.”

“What?” Adora laughed, shaking her head. “Oh my god, he’s not.”

Catra narrowed her eyes. “He’s basically a Ken doll.”

“You love Bow!” Adora cried.

“And Ken has his place. He makes great himbo arm candy.” Catra bit her lip. “If you’re into that sort of thing.”

“Bow is a lot more than himbo arm-candy,” Adora had that look in her eye, that little flare of life that said she was going to fight, fight hard and to the very end. Catra used to wonder if that’s where her eyes got their steely glint. “He’s an engineer, and a dad —”

“And you’re friends with him because he married your step-sister.”

“No!” Adora says, pointing a finger at Catra with a laugh on her breath. Catra had almost forgotten what that sounded like. “Bow was my friend *before* Glimmer was!”

Catra shook her head and picked up the menu. She was willing to concede. Almost. “Yeah, barely, because you were both nerds.”

Adora scoffed and picked her menu up too. “You were the one in all the gifted kid classes.”

“Yes, well I was smart.” Catra flipped to the back of the single-sheet menu. “That’s not the same as being a nerd.”

Adora looked up from her menu and watched Catra as she looked over the various sandwiches. Catra could feel the heat from Adora's stare and see her eyes out of her peripherals. Good lord, had they always been that shade of blue?

They had. Catra knew that. Those sky-blue eyes with the steel gray centers had haunted her for 20 years. And by the looks of it, they would haunt her for another twenty.

"How's it different?"

Catra looked up. "Huh?"

Adora smirked a little. "How is being smart different from being a nerd?"

Catra shrugged, turning her attention back to the menu. "Easy – I didn't have glasses."

Adora groaned. "I never wore them!"

Catra nodded slowly, flipping the menu again, pretending to be preoccupied with soup. "Yes, and you nearly fell flat on your ass every day because of it. Nerd."

Adora laughed, and the sound tinkled filling the air around them with warmth. Catra watched her face intently and tried to enjoy the sound without fixating on the holes in her chest that it echoed in.

Adora met Catra's gaze again, her face so soft and sweet that Catra worried it would break her.

"I've really missed you, Catra."

Catra forced an eye roll, knowing that if she did she'd be less likely to cry. "Yeah, yeah. Don't get sentimental on me."

Adora bit her bottom lip as Catra put down the menu and crossed her arms.

“So,” she started floundering a little. How is a satellite supposed to greet its world after returning to orbit. “How have you been?”

Adora rolled her eyes and shoulders. “Wow, um, where to start…”

Catra listened intently as Adora told her about the last few years and answered every question Catra could think to ask. She was finishing her master’s degree in statistics. She loved it, for some ungodly reason, and was really hoping she’d be able to find a job at a firm once she finished school. She’d just moved to a new neighborhood a little outside of Bright Moon proper. It was closer to the bank where she worked, and she was excited about the schools in the neighborhood. Her sister-in-law, Teela, actually worked at the elementary school teaching first grade. But Teela was going to go on maternity leave at the start of the next school year. She was pregnant with her and Adam’s first child. Glimmer and Bow’s son Archer was almost one.

And Finn had just turned five.

“Fuck,” Catra said, leaning back in her chair. “I can’t believe you have a five-year-old…”

Adora smiled. “Yeah. They’re pretty great though. Wanna see?”

Catra forced a smile for what felt like the millionth time, setting down her fork. “Yeah.”

Adora lifted her phone off the table where she’d set it at the start of the meal and started swiping through pictures. “They’re kind of a huge goof. The entire month of November I couldn’t get them out of their Halloween costume.” Adora turned the phone and Catra’s heart seized in her chest. “They were a dinosaur.”

It was like flying and falling all at once. They looked just like Adora. They had a crop of bright blonde hair and the toothiest, silliest grin Catra had ever seen. They were sitting on the couch, a bag of Cheetos in their lap, in a green triceratops costume with a hood that hung nearly down to their eyes. Their beautiful, sky-blue eyes. Just like their mom’s.

“Wow…” Catra sighed, leaning back and clutching at her shirt under the table. “They’re adorable.”

Adora turned the phone back to smile down at the picture. “Yeah. They’re kind of the best kid ever.”

Catra tried to smile. “They’ve been cute the whole time too. You’re like one of six people in the world who didn’t give birth to a glorified potato.”

Adora rolled her eyes and set her phone back down on the table. “Well, thanks. I think.”

“You’re welcome.”

Adora sighed, leaning forward on her hand. “My friend,” Catra arched a brow, “okay, Glimmer’s friend, lives down the street with her wife and they have a daughter. Her name’s Flora. She and Finn are practically joined at the hip now. It—” Adora smiled, but there was something sad in her eyes, “it kinda reminds me of us, actually.”

Catra gave a slow nod. She wondered if Flora was one of those generational names like Emily had been. And she ignored how her heart throbbed and the wounds in her chest ached.

She didn’t want to go down *that* road – nothing good laid at the end. “How’s Jordan?”

Adora looked almost hurt, wide eyed and slack mouthed. “You…” she furrowed her brow and sat up straighter, “You don’t know?”

Catra’s heart did the throbbing thing again and the wounds started to sting like someone was picking at them with salty fingers. “Know what?”

Adora sighed, reaching for her hand and twisting the ring on her finger. “Jordan and I got divorced.”

Catra blinked. She sat up a little straighter and bit the inside of her cheek. "Oh. I'm sorry. I—I didn't know."

Adora shakes her head. " *Don't* apologize. Please. Personally, I'm thrilled."

Catra nodded, glancing down into her lap. *It doesn't mean…* She bit the inside of her lip. *It doesn't mean* anything. She was still wearing a ring. A big, gaudy, engagement ring.

"So," Catra swallowed and nodded down at the ring, "who's the lucky guy?"

Adora looked up from her hand, startled. She glanced back down and wrinkled her nose. "Oh. No, this isn't an engagement ring. It's just…" she trailed off, fiddling with the ring again.

"Just…?" Catra lead, dipping her head down to catch Adora's eye.

Adora looked back at Catra with heavy eyes. She looked sad, and the light that had been radiating out of her the entire lunch was gone, like it had never been there at all.

"Just something I wear," she finally breathed, "to keep men from hitting on me."

"Ah," Catra nods, picking up her glass. "Got it. Maybe I should get me one of those…"

Adora smiled, but something about it didn't reach her eyes. "Yeah? So you have a boyfriend now?"

Catra choked on her drink, nearly coughing it up onto her salad. "No!" she shook her head, picking up her napkin and wiping her mouth. "Um, no… I… I guess I thought you knew." Catra rolled her eyes. "Kinda arrogant to think you saw my post though. And it was over a year ago."

Adora grimaced. "No, I—I saw it. I know."

Catra shoulders tensed as she took in Adora's face. "Look, if you have a problem—"

"No!" Adora nearly shouted, grabbing the edge of the table. "Of course not, Catra. I'm—I just didn't know how to bring it up, so I thought *that* was a good plan. I'm sorry. I'm… I'm happy for you."

Catra nodded and reached out to pick up her fork again. "Maybe you should make fewer plans that could lead to me drowning in a diner booth."

"Huh," Adora cocked her head. "I guess it would be drowning huh? Because liquid in the lungs…" Her eyes drifted off and Catra fought back the grin on her face. Adora's ramblings and thinking face had been two of her favorite things growing up. The way she would just talk and talk and talk, or stare off with a wrinkled brow…

"Anyway," Adora shook her head, bringing herself back down. Catra didn't feel like smiling anymore.

Adora had never been good at coming back to reality before. Just another reminder that she was different. Another reminder that she wasn't Catra's anymore.

Not that she ever really had been.

"You asked if I had a boyfriend," Catra reminded her and Adora dropped her head.

"Let's pretend I just said partner. Or, better yet," she met Catra's gaze again, "let's just forget I asked about your dating life at all."

Catra leaned into her palm. "So, you don't want to know about my dating life?"

Adora shook her head. "No, I do. But we're gonna pretend you're the one who brought it up."

Catra snickered. "We are, huh?"

Adora nodded her head briskly. “Yes.”

“Okay,” Catra stabbed at her salad and tried to find the right words. “My dating life is basically a dead fish. I hate dating apps and never connect with the people I meet on them. I spend most of my nights off with a bottle of wine and new show on Netflix.”

Adora leaned forward, resting her head on her hand and giving Catra her full attention. “What shows?”

Catra then proceeded to tell her about all the gay cartoons and cheesy lesbian dramas she watched. She told her about looking for work as a freelance writer but struggling to find anything without many credentials and how she’d been working as a manager at a movie theater. She told her about all of her college friends moving out of town and living in a tiny 800 sq ft apartment with Entrapta and her cat.

“You have a cat!” Adora’s face lit up. “Do you have pictures?”

Catra shook her head and smirked but brought out her phone and pulled up a picture of Melog. She showed it to Adora, who cooed and stroked the screen like she could pet them through it.

“But, yeah,” Catra reached across the table, picking her phone back up and shrugging. “That’s kinda it. Not a lot going on.”

Adora sighed, leaning back. “I don’t believe that.”

“What do you mean?” Catra asked, stilling.

Adora shrugged, eyes locked on the pockmarked ceiling. “You’re brilliant, Catra. And you’re going places.” She dropped her gaze back down. “I’ve always known that.”

Catra felt her face warm up and coughed quietly to find her voice. “Thanks, Adora, but I think I’m ready to settle for a life of mediocrity.”

Adora furrowed her brow and pursed her lips. “That’s not—”

“Besides,” Catra cut her off, waving her hand. “I don’t really care what I’m doing. I just—” she sighed, mustering up courage and stockpiling it in her stomach. “As long as I’m not alone?” She tried to smile. “You know. I’d like to meet someone eventually.”

Adora smiled back. “You’ve always been a secret romantic.”

“Okay,” Catra rolled her eyes, “enough of that.”

Adora shook her head. “Nope! It’s cute. You were always wanting to play wedding…”

“Yeah, I’m not gonna talk about this. Ever.” Catra stabbed at her salad again and shoved the offending greens into her mouth. She wasn’t ready for Adora to read into it. She wasn’t ready for Adora to realize, like she did years later, that in all of those little play weddings they never once changed their names.

Adora snickered. “And I was always making you play, like, ‘survivor’ or whatever. Like we were stranded on an island or in the woods…”

Catra grimaced. “You took a bunch of marichino cherries out of your fridge and said they were turtle eggs.”

Adora laughed, throwing her head back. “Oh my god, I remember that.”

“You made me eat three.”

Adora laughed harder, and when her eyes fell back on Catra’s face, her smile was warm and soft and sweet. “You—” she took a deep breath, “you were such an amazing friend.”

Catra returns the smile. “So were you.”

Adora shook her head, straightening in her seat. “No, I wasn’t. And that’s—that’s part of why I wanted to see you today.”

Catra's heart picked up its pace, and then Adora was reaching across the table and picking up her hand.

Catra nearly short-circuited at the feeling of Adora's strong, callused hands wrapping around hers.

"Catra," she looked up into Adora's eyes and they were so focused and serious, like a stormy sky, "I'm sorry."

"What are—"

"I took you for granted," Adora went on, squeezing Catra's hand. "You were always there for me, always. And you did so much for me. I—god it's pathetic—but I didn't know what I was losing until you were gone. And I'm sorry. You deserved better than what I gave you."

Catra's breath was stuck in her throat. She was completely at a loss. There were some things she just thought she'd never talk about – things that not even her therapist knew. Her unconditional heartbreaking love for Adora was one of them. She figured she'd just spend the rest of her life mourning, wishing that the only person she'd ever loved with her whole, unrestrained heart had loved her too.

She didn't expect an apology. She didn't expect Adora ever even felt the loss.

And it was like taking a hammer to her very pathetic excuse for self-control.

"Adora, I… I don't know what to say."

Adora's smile was sad, and she started to pull her hand away. "You don't have to say anything, Catra. I just wanted you to know." She dropped her hands into her lap. "I have… a lot of regrets, but losing you is… one of the bigger ones."

Catra took a deep breath and crossed her arms over her stomach. "It wasn't just you. I was… needy. I expected a lot from you,"

Catra closed her eyes, trying to remember all the justifications she'd given Adora over the years. "And I didn't reach out much either. Then you moved. It just—it happens."

"You were mad." Catra's head snapped up, and Adora's eyes were pinched with silent torment. "And you had every right to be."

Catra rolled her eyes. "I was 14. It's fine."

Adora shook her head. "No, it wasn't. It's not. Catra, I—"

"God!" Catra snapped, shaking her head to keep tears from pooling in her eyes. "I get it. You're sorry. Okay! I—I forgive you." Catra buried her head in her hands. "You didn't do anything wrong, Adora." She took a deep and filling breath. "You just… you moved on."

Catra looked up to see tears in Adora's eyes.

Fuck.

Catra scared her. Catra upset her. She didn't want to. She didn't mean to. This was why Adora had dropped her in the first place. Catra was too loud, too emotional. Catra was needy and pathetic.

Catra wasn't "cool" enough. She wasn't good enough. At least, not for Adora.

"I'm—I'm sorry I yelled," Catra muttered. "I just—can we talk about something else?"

Adora nodded, dropping her gaze to the table. Her phone screen lit up and she reached over to pick it up.

"Oh shit!" Adora tapped her screen. "Is that what time it is?"

Catra tried to crack a smile. "Cellphones are usually right about the time."

Adora looked up and waved down their waiter. “I’m sorry,” she grimaced. “I have to go.”

Catra blanched, resisting the urge to pull on her hair and scream. “Oh…”

The waiter stopped at the table. “Yes,” Adora smiled at him with bright eyes and warmth, “I need the check. And,” she glanced at Catra, “Two boxes?”

Catra looked down at her salad and the half-eaten bowl of soup. Her stomach turned at the thought of eating, much less from this godforsaken place, ever again. “No, I’m good.”

Adora nodded. “Just one box then. Thank you.”

The waiter smiled and Adora shoved her credit card into his hand.

Catra opened her mouth to protest, reaching into her bag to grab her card, and Adora shook her head. “No, I invited you to lunch. I’m paying.”

“Okay,” Catra sighed, feeling defeated. This wasn’t how she wanted this to go. She wanted this to be the beginning of something. She wanted to be Adora’s friend again.

Instead Adora was faking an emergency so she could leave.

Adora was leaving her. Again.

And maybe it was about time she stopped hoping she would come back.

“Thanks for lunch,” Catra said, clenching her fists in her lap so that her nails were digging into her skin and grounding her. “It was nice to catch up.”

Adora smiled, but Catra could tell it was fake now; forced. “Yeah! I’m really glad we did this. Maybe we could do it again?”

"Have a nice life you fucking freak."

"Yeah," Catra smiled but she knew it didn't reach her eyes. "I'd like that."

The waiter was back, handing Adora her card, a box, and a copy of the receipt. Adora took it, signed it quickly, and stood. "I'm really sorry I have to leave like this," she said, grabbing her bag off the seat and shoving her phone in her pocket. "It's just Finn—"

Catra's smile never wavered. "It's fine. I get it."

Adora nodded, then held her hand out. "Can I walk you to your car?"

Catra blinked at the hand, realizing that Adora was offering to help her out of her seat. She was offering to walk her to her car.

Catra shook her head. "It's cool. I need to go to the bathroom."

Adora lowered her hand. "Oh."

She stepped back and Catra stood. She pulled her own bag off the seat and stepped around Adora in the direction of the restrooms. "Have a good rest of your day."

Adora didn't move. "You too."

Catra walked into the bathroom, stepped into a stall, and punched the tiled wall as hard as she dared.

Five minutes later she walked out and Adora was gone, the empty Styrofoam box still sitting on the table. Catra scoffed and walked out to her car, pulled away from the restaurant and headed back to FZC.

And Catra cried the entire drive home.

Adora stepped through the door of Glimmer and Bow's house and was immediately accosted by a tiny body with blonde hair and a bright, warm, giggle.

"Mom!" Finn buried their head in their mother's stomach. "You're back!"

Adora smiled, running her fingers through Finn's hair. "Yeah. Why, did you miss me?"

Finn tipped their head back and Adora was met by brilliant blue eyes. "No."

Adora laughed, reaching down and lifting Finn into her arms. "Not at all?"

They shook their head, but they couldn't stop smiling. "Nope! You're boring."

A ripple of joy coursed through Adora and she laughed again. "I'm not boring. You're boring."

Finn shook their head. "No, you're boring. Glimmer's boring too."

"Hey!" Glimmer cried from the kitchen. "I'm not boring!"

Finn sighed, and Adora put them back on the ground. "Is Bow boring?" Adora asked.

"No," Finn replied, matter of fact. "But Bow had to go to the store."

"Ah." Adora nodded, taking her child by the hand and walking into the kitchen. "Why did Bow have to go to the store?"

Glimmer groaned and shot Adora a very tired look. "We're out of milk. And Finny's been asking for mac n' cheese for the last two hours."

Adora looked down into Finn's sheepish face. "Finn… you're supposed to eat whatever Aunt Glimmer and Uncle Bow make you."

"They asked me!"

Glimmer nodded, glancing back at a pot of water that had yet to boil. "We did. We just made the mistake of asking two hours early."

Adora rolled her eyes. "Rookie mistake."

Glimmer scoffed. "No kidding." When Glimmer caught sight of Adora's face her eyes narrowed, and Adora bit her lip. Did her mascara run? Could Glimmer tell she'd been crying? Why did she even wear mascara anyway? What did she expect to happen? Did she really think—

"Hey, Finn? Go finish your episode of *Star* , then hopefully dinner will be ready."

"Okay!" Finn pulled their hand from Adora's and darted into the adjacent room. In seconds Glimmer and Adora could hear the sounds of *Star vs. the Forces of Evil* drifting through the open doorway.

Glimmer immediately turned on Adora and crossed her arms. "What happened?"

Adora sighed and threw her bag on the kitchen island. "I thought you needed me to pick them up by five."

Glimmer shrugged. "Eh, Scorpia and Perfuma cancelled. Some emergency with one of Scorpia's friends. Not a big deal."

"You could've texted me," Adora groaned, climbing into one of the barstools at the counter.

"I figured you were busy. I didn't want to bother you." Glimmer narrowed her eyes. "Why, what happened?"

Adora shook her head, anger shuddering in her stomach. “I don’t wanna talk about it, Glimmer.”

“Adora—”

Adora buried her head in her hands and fought back the urge to cry. She ruined everything, *everything* , for nothing. Glimmer and Bow could’ve kept Finn for hours. She could’ve been with Catra for *hours* . Instead, she ran out right after… after…

Adora felt a hand on her back and looked up to see Glimmer was standing beside her and rubbing small circles. “Did… did you tell her?”

“No.” Adora nearly choked on a sob. “I tried, but I couldn’t do it. And I don’t—” Adora shook her head, “I don’t think I’m ever gonna see her again.”

Glimmer sighed and wrapped her arm around Adora’s shoulders. “It’s okay, hon. Maybe it’s for the best.”

Adora didn’t argue, but she knew Glimmer was wrong. Adora knew beyond a shadow of a doubt that Catra should’ve been in her life. She knew she should’ve been there the whole time. And she didn’t want to miss her anymore.

She wanted the chance to show Catra how much she loved her. That she’d always loved her.

She wanted Catra worse than she ever had.

And now she was gone.

End Notes

I named Adora's ex-husband Jordan for Jordan Fischer because he voices Sea Hawk and that was Adora's love interest in the original She-Ra and--you get it.

I know I had more thoughts for the author's notes when I was writing it. But I hope you liked it. Comments and kudos appreciated!

OH! And thanks to Raptor_Red and Booksmyrt for betaing! It was... needed.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!